Breaches of faith

One group of people the President did not consult was his allies. There were understandable security concerns about disclosing a decision to launch a surprise attack. Kennedy remarked 'warning them [US allies], it seems to me, is warning everybody.'[49] Vice President Lyndon Johnson also argued against consulting allies (or Congress), even though he acknowledged this would be 'a breach of faith.'[50] According to Article Four of the NATO Treaty: 'the Parties will consult together whenever, in the opinion of any of them, the territorial integrity, political independence or security of any of the Parties is threatened.' The more politically significant argument was made by Dean Rusk: 'If we go with the quick strike, then, they do back it up, it … then you have exposed all of your allies and ourselves to all these great dangers without the slightest consultation, or warning, or preparation.'[51] Rusk spoke of wanting a few days to consult within NATO. The United States had forty-two allies, he explained, including members of the Organisation of American States, which had previously helped in the diplomatic and economic isolation of Cuba. Kennedy, however, was unpersuaded: 'I don't think we ought to do the OAS. I think that's a waste of time. I don't think we ought to do NATO.'[52]

There was recognition, including by the Joint Chiefs, that the allies needed to be told shortly in advance of an attack. But there was little appetite outside the State Department to consult. When it came to the British, Kennedy was blunt: 'I don't know how much use consulting with the British [is]… I expect they'll just object. Just have to decide to do it. Probably ought to tell them, though, the night before.'[53] Kennedy's view of his closest ally was understandable. Like other European members of NATO, they had learned to live under threat of Soviet MRBMs. But the British had also adopted a posture on Cuba that was unhelpful to Washington. They opposed various trading and shipping sanctions against Havana and dragged their feet over restricting transfer of specified technologies. When the Foreign Secretary, Lord Home, visited Washington in early October, Macmillan cabled him: 'I hope we shall not agree to COCOM [Co-ordinating Committee on Export Controls] or anything